Mirza, who was then deployed in an Afghan army battalion at Jowz-jan province in northern Afghanistan, and noted his hunger for power. 'He is a bird on the wing, encage him,' the Indian spies were told.

Reviewing the performance of his government, Afghanistan's president, Nur Muhammad Taraki, was satisfied. He was consolidating state power with the expansion of party cadres and he was able to legislate a thorough socio-economic programme despite some turbulence. The R&AW supported Taraki but to ensure a wider base of assets, the agency recruited key figures from other factions as well. Taraki was unaware that a bloody war was lurking on the horizon. A R&AW dispatch revealed that on 14 February 1979, the first sign of the war arrived with the assassination of the USA ambassador in Kabul, Adolph Dubs. R&AW spies said Dubs was apparently killed in crossfire between the urban guerrillas who had abducted him and the Afghan security forces. There was good reason for the Indians to believe that the Afghan security forces had used maximum force without adequate consideration for the life of the USA ambassador.

January and February 1979 had seen both Shia and Sunni mullahs arrested throughout Afghanistan. Important amongst those arrested were Ibrahim Mujahidi alias Hazrat Sahib of Shor Bazar, a top Sunni leader. R&AW field agents reported that about forty of his disciples, including Mir Yusuf, Abdur Rehman and Noor Iqbal, had also been rounded up. Amongst the arrested Shia leaders were Syed Kiyan, Sheikh Mohammad Waiz, Yusuf Binish and Majeed Riasi. The inevitable result of these arrests had been grave discontent and frustration amongst conservative sections of the population.